"But I know several European friends of India who have told me distinctly that their interest in the Indian freedom movement is due entirely to Gandhi's method of non-violent resistance."

Mr. Rolland did not agree with them at all. He would be sorry if Satyagraha failed. But if it really did, the hard facts of life would have to be faced and he would like to see the movement conducted on other lines.

That was the answer nearest to my heart! Here then was an idealist, who did not build castles in the air but who had his feet planted on terra firma.

"What would be Mr. Rolland's attitude," I continued, "if the United Front policy of the Indian National Congress fails to win freedom for India and a radical party emerges which identifies itself with the interests of the peasants and the workers?"

M. Rolland was clearly of opinion that the time had come for the Congress to take a definite stand on economic issues. "I have already written to Gandhi", said he, "that he would make up his mind on this question."

Explaining his attitude in the event of a scheme within the Indian Congress, he continued, "I am not interested in choosing between two political parties or between two generations. What is of interest and of value to me is a higher question. To me, political parties do not count. What really counts in the great cause that transcends them, the cause of the workers of the world. To be more explicit, if as a result of unfortunate circumstance, Gandhi (or any party, for the matter of that) should be in conflict with the cause of the workers, and with their necessary evolution towards a socialistic organisation—if Gandhi (or any party) should turn away and stand aloof from the workers' cause, then for ever will I side with the oppressed workers—for ever will I participate in their efforts and in their combats because on their side is justice and the law of the real and necessary development of human society."

I was delighted and amazed. Even in my most optimistic moods I had never expected this great thinker to come out so openly and boldly in support of the workers' cause.

The strain resulting from our animated conversation was great and I felt anxious for the delicate health of my host. However, a relief came when tea was announced and we all moved into the adjoining room.